

UTTAR PRADESH



Mayawati

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

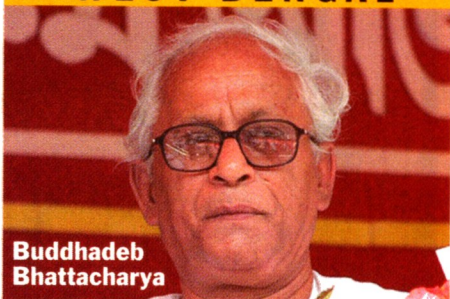
	BSP	SP+	BJP+
STAR NEWS	137	96	108
NDTV	117-127	113-123	108-118
CNN-IBN	152-168	99-111	80-90

ACTUAL SEATS 206 97 51

Mayawati exposed them like never before. Far from predicting the biggest sweep seen after BJP's 221 in 1991, pollsters were predicting a dead heat. Of course, they also predicted a revival of BJP in the Hindi heartland.

Elections were held in May 2007

WEST BENGAL



Buddhadeb Bhattacharya

SUVASHIS MULLICK

	LEFT+	TC+BJP	CONG
STAR ANANDA	207	44	34
KOLKATA TV	195-205	46-54	30-35
CNN-IBN	230-240	32-40	17-23

ACTUAL SEATS 235 30 21

It was a no-brainer in terms of who would win. Neither the Congress nor the Trinamul-BJP alliance were close to three digits but only one poll could capture the true reach of the red brigade.

Elections were held in May 2006; Left comprises CPI(M), CPI and five other parties

BIHAR



Nitish Kumar

RAVI S SAHANI

	RJD+CONG	JD(U)+BJP	LJP	Others
STAR NEWS	87	119	16	21
ZEE NEWS	89	117	18	19
CNN-IBN	72-80	130-140	9-14	17-22

ACTUAL SEATS 63 143 10 27

The low-profile Nitish Kumar had them foxed. Most pollsters simply failed to read the anger against the RJD or the groundswell of support for the JD(U)-BJP alliance, even those who spotted the winner missed the drubbing of RJD.

Elections were held in Nov 2005; RJD won 54 seats and Congress 9

MAHARASHTRA



Vilasrao Deshmukh

UNESH GOSWAMI

	CONG+NCP	BJP+SS	Others
AAJ TAK	140-150	100-110	30-40
NDTV	120-130	125-135	30-45
STAR NEWS	142	122	24
ZEE NEWS	125	115	48

ACTUAL SEATS 140 116 32

It was a close fight with Pramod Mahajan taking on the Maratha might. Eventually the might of the Maratha factor won the day for the NCP-Congress combine. Only Aaj Tak got it right on two counts.

Elections were held in Oct 2004; Congress won 69 seats and NCP 71

RJD. Of course, the problem with exit polls is more than just the contextual, spatial or geographic exigencies. Its challenge lies in the complexity of the mass being studied. In India, the mass of humanity is homogenous to the extent of the species and immediately thereafter is segmented across caste, class, language, occupation and com-

munal lines. So interpreting exit polls is tough and could go wrong because those who are reading the tea leaves are but human. Add to that externalities like media hype and ideological conflict.

No, an exit poll cannot be the real thing and is not meant to be. But what would help it as an instrument of analysing popular mood is a more clin-

ical approach that is not affected by personalities or ideology and is less intimidated by the 24-hour news environment. Yes, it is difficult but not as difficult as forecasting GDP growth of the country and the economists get it right more often than not. At least when they don't, they are able to offer an acceptable explanation.